



TRAITORS AND PATRIOTS

BY HOLDEN DENYER

TRAITORS, PATRIOTS, AND NARRATIVES



Patriotism and treachery—two powerful, opposing forces that have shaped history, toppled empires, and defined entire nations. But what do these labels mean to us in our everyday lives?

Here, we'll explore the blurry line between these seemingly individual concepts. We will dive into stories of iconic traitors and patriots, modern-day whistleblowers and insurrectionists, and challenge what it means to be truly loyal to one's country, people, and ideals.

The truth is, we are all participants in such a story. All of us, in our own ways, make choices that could cast us as either a patriot or a traitor—much of which depends on who's holding the pen.

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Lazy Liberalism and Performative Patriotism

Scrolling through Instagram during the height of the Black Lives Matter protests, or other instances of political strife, you might have come across posts urging you to share a graphic or repost a hashtag. It's an era of "instagraphics"—easily shareable content that lets us signal our political stances without leaving our comfort zones.

The New Republic's critique of this trend as "lazy liberalism" hits hard as it strikes at an uncomfortable truth: activism has become, in part, about the appearance of doing something rather than truly challenging structures of power.

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It begs the question: Is this a new form of patriotism, or is it something less? Does it make us heroes in the fight for justice, or are we simply traitors to true progress, betraying the causes we claim to support by choosing to only engage superficially?

This kind of performative activism reflects a hollow patriotism—a loyalty to looking the part without making the sacrifices necessary for meaningful change.

It is the very challenge of our times: to be truly loyal to the ideals we pledge to, not just on our feeds, but in our actions.



Cancel Culture: Accountability or Modern-Day Witch Hunt?

The influence of cancel culture only adds another layer to this complexity. What can start as a lighthearted internet joke could evolve into a cultural battleground where people are publicly shamed, stripped of their platforms, and often exiled from their careers. Is this an act of collective justice—holding individuals accountable—or have we embraced a modern-day witch hunt, one that makes us both judge and jury with a few taps and types on our screens?

There exists a sense of irony in cancel culture. Often, it marks similarity to the very forces of oppression it claims to fight. On one hand, it empowers people to demand accountability, but on the other, it can become an exercise in power, where we “cancel” not for the greater good but to demonstrate our own moral superiority.

As we judge and cancel, we have to ask ourselves: Are we patriots defending justice, or traitors to the ideals of free speech and redemption?

The Patriot Within Us All

At the core of this piece lies an essential exploration: What does it mean to be a patriot in a world where values, loyalties, and actions are scrutinized on such public stages?

For some, it's about supporting the state no matter what. For others, patriotism means challenging authority, pushing for accountability, sacrificing personal comfort for collective progress. Patriotism in the modern age is not a one-size-fits-all badge. It is messy, complex, and deeply tied to our ever-evolving values.

The stories and figures we will discuss: Donald Trump, Edward Snowden, the Confederates, George Washington, are all reflections of the timeless push and pull of patriotism and treachery. But more importantly, they mirror the choices we all face in our daily lives.

Each of us has the capacity to be a patriot or a traitor, to make choices that either push us toward meaningful change or hold us back in a comfortable complacency.

Are you willing to risk comfort for progress? Are you brave enough to challenge the narratives handed to you, or do you find solace in going with the flow?

In the end, the story of traitors and patriots is not just about history—it's about the decisions we make each and every day, the narratives we choose to believe, and the kind of future we want to build together.



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PATRIOTISM WITHOUT PROGRESSION



TTrue patriotism demands progress. But what happens when people hold back change under the guise of preserving “ideals”?

In such is a tale of how patriotism and treachery blur, and how success, or lack thereof, ultimately determines whether you’re cheered as a hero or condemned as a villain. Strap in as we revisit two infamous case studies: the Confederacy and George Washington—two sides of the same treasonous coin, yet celebrated differently.

Confederate Patriots: A Traitor's Lament

In 1861, the Confederacy claimed patriotism through loyalty to the founding values of independence and self-determination. They even pointed to the Declaration of Independence's right to "alter or abolish" government as justification for their rebellion. This was patriotic rhetoric, sure—but make no mistake, every Confederate soldier and leader was a traitor under the U.S. Constitution's definition of treason, which is "levying war against [the government]."

Yet, despite the constitutional clarity, President Jefferson Davis was not tried, nor were Confederate leaders executed. Instead, leniency prevailed, as Northerners focused on reconciliation rather than revenge.

The Confederacy's patriotism ultimately failed because it was a brand of patriotism that hindered progress—progress that meant unity, the end of human enslavement, and the creation of a stronger, more inclusive nation. The Confederates fought to preserve an ideal that had no place in an evolving society, and in the process, secured their place as traitors.

Their patriotism was ultimately selfish, and the lack of success cemented them in history as rebels against the very union they claimed to represent.

George Washington: A Traitor with Better PR

George Washington—a traitor turned patriot. Washington actively defied the British monarchy, betrayed the crown, and committed high treason by all accounts.

Had the Revolutionary War ended differently, we might see his powdered wig on some "Wanted" poster in a museum of British history. But Washington and his compatriots succeeded, and through that success, he was able to reframe treason as patriotism.

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He became the founding father of a new nation rather than an executed dissident.

Washington's story is a perfect example of how success can white-wash treason into heroism. It begs the question: what separates patriots from traitors?

The Confederates and George Washington both rebelled against the established authority of their time, yet only one succeeded in forging a new national identity. In Washington's case, his rebellion was in service of progress—breaking free from colonial oppression to create something new.

That narrative worked in his favor, whereas the Confederates tried to preserve an outdated status quo.

Progress or Bust

Patriotism without progression is just conservatism in disguise, a fear of change dressed up as loyalty. True patriots are those who dare to push their country forward—not cling to fading ideals in an attempt to drag society backwards. Whether it's the Confederates waving their flags of “freedom” or George Washington rallying against colonial rule, the deciding factor in how history remembers you is your impact on progress.

If your so-called patriotism stands in the way of bettering the collective well-being, you might just find yourself on the wrong side of history—and remembered as a traitor. Conversely, if you succeed in driving meaningful change, then congratulations: you're officially a patriot, no matter how treasonous your path was to get there.

“HISTORY IS
WRITTEN
BY THE VICTOR”

—VICTOR





MODERN TRAITORS AND PATRIOTS



In today's polarized world, it's hard to tell who's wearing the white hats and who's donning the black ones. The definition of patriotism and treachery is murkier than ever, with both sides of the political spectrum pointing fingers and slinging accusations. From insurrectionists to whistleblowers, the question of who's a hero and who's a traitor depends largely on which channel you're watching.

Let's dive into two recent figures who embody this ambiguity, Donald Trump and Edward Snowden. Star examples of actions which have drawn both praise and condemnation.

Donald Trump and the Capitol Riots: A New Confederate Spirit?

Donald Trump loves to paint himself as a defender of American greatness and ideals, a patriot waging a heroic battle against the “deep state.” But if we take off the MAGA-tinted glasses, his actions during and after the 2020 election were more akin to the Confederate leaders of 1861 than any patriotic saviors of American democracy.

On January 6th, 2021, we witnessed an angry mob storm the U.S. Capitol, driven by misinformation and conspiracy theories—many of which rooted in Trump’s rhetoric and his endorsement of QAnon conspiracies.

To Carlton Larson, a treason scholar, the Capitol insurrection was a clear case of “levying war” against the United States, which meets the constitutional definition of treason. Trump and his followers made claims of patriotism, insisting they were protecting the sanctity of the election, but their actions threatened the very foundation of American democracy.

It’s the Confederate spirit in modern attire; claims of loyalty that actually tear away at the fabric of unity and equality.

The January 6th rioters called themselves patriots, but history is likely to be less kind. The Confederate comparison isn’t just hyperbole either; like their 19th-century counterparts, they fought under the banner of a twisted version of freedom that ultimately sought to prevent the collective progress of the nation.

In the end, it seems success will once again decide whether they’re remembered as misguided heroes or outright traitors—and end which becomes increasingly uncertain after Trump’s recent re-election.



Edward Snowden: Hero of Privacy or Betrayer of Trust?

Edward Snowden is a different kind of divisive figure, one whose treachery/patriotism debate hinges not on violence, but values. In 2013, Snowden exposed the surveillance practices of the U.S. government, revealing that intelligence agencies were spying on citizens at an unprecedented scale. To the U.S. government, Snowden is a traitor who violated the Espionage Act and compromised national security. To citizens all around the world, Snowden is a hero who revealed how much privacy had been surrendered in the name of safety.

Snowden himself has always insisted that his allegiance lies with the people, not the state. He argued that his duty to protect the Constitution outweighed any loyalty to the government agencies violating it. “I used to work for the government; now I work for the public,” Snowden stated in a Daily Show interview. His actions sparked global debates about privacy, freedom, and the balance between security and individual rights.

The fact that he lives in exile in Russia complicates his narrative, as critics argue it adds question to his credibility as a patriot. Still, to his supporters, Snowden stands as an example of someone willing to sacrifice his own safety to reveal truths, even if they are uncomfortable risks.

The ambiguity of Snowden’s status—patriot or traitor—is a reflection of these politically divided times which we live in. His story forces us to ask ourselves where our loyalties lie: with the government, the institutions, or with the people whose rights are often treated as collateral damage.

In an era where the line between right and wrong is blurred, Snowden is a reminder that treachery and heroism can be so closely related, defined by their relative success.

PATRIOTS, TRAITORS, AND THE NARRATIVES WE CHOOSE TO BELIEVE



Ultimately, the difference between modern traitors and patriots comes down to the narratives we choose to believe. Donald Trump, Edward Snowden, and their supporters all claim to be acting in the best interest of America. But who defines what's best? Does the end justify the means? History will likely answer these questions in ways we can't yet predict, influenced by whose vision for the country prevails.

One thing is clear, though: whether you're remembered as a patriot or a traitor depends on which side of progress you fall on. Whether your actions help move us forward or pull us back.

The line between traitor and patriot is as thin as it is fluid, constantly shifting based on who's writing the story. Throughout history, we've seen individuals who have been both vilified and venerated, sometimes simultaneously, and it all depends on the narrative that emerges victorious. In just the cases we've explored, it seems that patriotism and treachery are not defined by the morality of actions alone, but rather by their outcomes, their success, and the collective myths that are created in the aftermath.

To the American psyche, success is the great legitimizer. George Washington's rebellion against the British became a revolutionary triumph because it succeeded; the Confederates' struggle to preserve their way of life, however twisted, ended in failure and cemented them as traitors in the history books. Donald Trump's attempt to challenge the democratic process of 2020 will ideally be remembered similarly—a failed act of resistance that jeopardized the very foundation of democracy, rather than a heroic defense of American values. Yet, he may now have the power to write that story.

Edward Snowden's case is a bit more complicated. He succeeded in exposing a truth that challenged the ideals and impressions of many, yet he remains an exile. His narrative teeters on a precipice, with some seeing him as a heroic whistleblower protecting civil liberties, others viewing him as a traitor who compromised national security. His story is far from settled; it depends on which future emerges, and which narrative becomes accepted.

Patriotism today is not as straightforward as waving a flag or pledging allegiance. It is a nuanced stance that challenges us to think critically about what loyalty truly means—loyalty to the state, loyalty to the people, loyalty to progress.

The modern era demands that we look beyond the symbols of patriotism and understand the intentions and consequences behind them. Are we progressing as a society, or merely preserving the status quo under a guise of loyalty?

The truth is that the designation of “patriot” or “traitor” often tells us more about the people bestowing the label than it does about the actions themselves. It’s a reflection of our values, our fears, and our aspirations. It’s about the kind of society we want to build and who we choose to uplift or condemn as we build it. Heroes are made by their victories, but also by the stories we decide to tell about them.

In such, narratives hold immense power. The story of America is one of shifting loyalties and evolving definitions of who deserves to be celebrated and who must be condemned. The difference between patriot and traitor often comes down to whose story is being told, who gets to tell it, and how the rest of us choose to listen.

The ultimate question is: What kind of progress do we, as a society, want to be remembered for? Are we willing to adapt, challenge, and redefine what loyalty and progress look like, or will we stay entrenched in a world of outdated ideals? Patriotism without progression is stagnation, a hollow loyalty that serves only to hold us back.

As we look forward, it’s up to each of us to decide what kind of patriots we want to be. Will we fight for progress, for justice, for collective well-being? Or will we let the fear of change hold us hostage, disguising our resistance as patriotism?

The choice is ours, and the story is still being written.



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